

Independent Reading

Grade 6

Students entering grade 6 are expected to read at least **two independent reading books**. Students are encouraged to choose from the suggested titles on the pages that follow. In the event that a student wishes to make an alternate selection, we ask that families take an active role in helping students select an appropriate independent reading title.

For other suggestions, please check out [YALSA's book awards and book lists](#) for a selection of award-winning titles.

Note: Students will discuss their independent reading selections in September—There is no written requirement.

Please Note:

Many books on our independent reading list are available as eBooks through [FollettShelf](#) or the [Sora](#) app. Titles with an active hyperlink are available as eBooks. Students should use their school username and password to access the site. Contact bbarthelmes@byramhills.org with any questions about using eBooks.

Quantities are limited



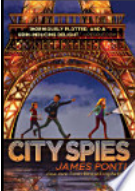
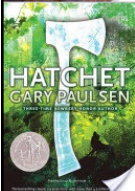
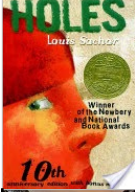
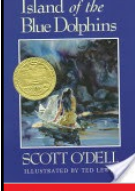
Challenging Read



Recommended for the Reluctant Reader

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Adventure			
	<u>City Spies</u>	James Ponti	Operating out of a base in Scotland, the City Spies are five kids from various parts of the world. When they're not attending the local boarding school, they're honing their unique skills, such as sleight of hand, breaking and entering, observation, and explosives. All of these allow them to go places in the world of espionage where adults can't.
	<u>Hatchet</u>	Gary Paulsen	After a plane crash, thirteen-year-old Brian spends fifty-four days in the wilderness, learning to survive initially with only the aid of a hatchet given him by his mother, and learning also to survive his parents' divorce. (Audiobook available)
	<u>Holes</u>	Louis Sachar	As further evidence of his family's bad fortune which they attribute to a curse on a distant relative, Stanley Yelnats is sent to a hellish correctional camp in the Texas desert where he finds his first real friend, a treasure, and a new sense of himself. (Audiobook available)
	<u>Hoot</u>	Carl Hiaasen	Roy, who is new to his small Florida community, becomes involved in another boy's attempt to save a colony of burrowing owls from a proposed construction site. (Audiobook available)
	<u>Island of the Blue Dolphins</u> 	Scott O'Dell	Left alone on a beautiful but isolated island off the coast of California, a young Indian girl spends eighteen years, not only merely surviving through her enormous courage and self-reliance, but also finding a measure of happiness in her solitary life. (Audiobook available)
	<u>Scat</u>	Carl Hiaasen	Nick and his friend Marta decide to investigate when a mysterious fire starts near a Florida wildlife preserve and an unpopular teacher goes missing.



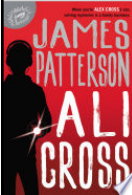
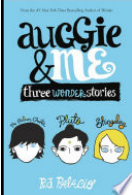
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	<i>Stormbreaker</i> or any book in <u>The Alex Rider Series</u>	Anthony Horowitz	<i>Stormbreaker</i> : After the death of the uncle who had been his guardian, fourteen-year-old Alex Rider is coerced to continue his uncle's dangerous work for Britain's intelligence agency, MI6. (Audiobook available). Other titles in the series include: Point Blank Eagle Strike Scorpia Ark Angel Snakehead Crocodile Tears Scorpia Rising Russian Roulette Skeleton Key
Realistic Fiction			
	<i>A Mango-Shaped Space</i>	Wendy Mass	Afraid that she is crazy, thirteen-year-old Mia, who sees a special color with every letter, number, and sound, keeps this a secret until she becomes overwhelmed by school, changing relationships, and the loss of something important to her.
	<i>Ali Cross</i>	James Patterson	James Patterson's blockbuster <i>Alex Cross</i> series has sold over 100 million copies—and now he's bringing those thrills to a new generation! Alex's son Ali is eager to follow in his father's footsteps as a detective, but when his best friend goes missing, what price will he have to pay to solve the mystery?
	<i>Augie & Me</i>	R.J. Palacio	Millions of readers have fallen in love with Auggie Pullman, an ordinary boy with an extraordinary face. Wonder tells his story from six different perspectives, but there were some characters whose unique perspectives were not shared—until now.
	<i>Because of Mr. Terupt</i> 	Rob Buyea	Seven fifth-graders at Snow Hill School in Connecticut relate how their lives are changed for the better by "rookie teacher" Mr. Terupt. This title is the first book in a series.



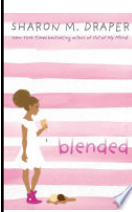
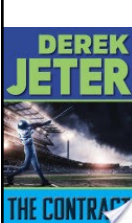
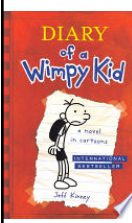
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Realistic Fiction			
	<i>Blended</i>	Sharon M. Draper	Eleven-year-old Isabella's parents are divorced, so she has to switch lives every week: One week she's Isabella with her dad, his girlfriend Anastasia, and her son Darren living in a fancy house where they are one of the only black families in the neighborhood. The next week she's Izzy with her mom and her boyfriend John-Mark in a small, not-so-fancy house that she loves.
	<i>The Cat Ate My Gymsuit</i> 😊	Paula Danziger	Marcy Lewis has a lot to deal with--a clinging mother, an angry father, a lousy school situation, and the inescapable fact that she is fat. But when Mrs. Barbara Finney arrives to take over Marcy's English class, suddenly nothing in Marcy's life will be the same.
	<i>The Contract</i>	Derek Jeter	As a young boy, Derek Jeter dreams of being the shortstop for the New York Yankees. He even imagines himself in the World Series. So when Derek is chosen for the Little League Tigers, he hopes to play shortstop. But on the day of the assignments, Derek Starts at second base. Still, he tries his best while he wishes and dreams of that shortstop spot. And to help him stay focused on school, his parents make him a contract: keep up the grades or no baseball. Derek makes sure he always plays his best game—on and off the baseball field!
	<i>Diary of a Wimpy Kid series</i>	Jeff Kinney	Things aren't going well for Greg Heffley. He's been thrust into a new school where undersize weaklings share the corridors with kids who are taller, meaner and already shaving. With his friend Rowley, Greg's desperate to prove his new maturity, which only going up a grade can bring. But when Rowley's star starts to rise, will Greg be able to reach the same heights of popularity as Rowley?
	<i>Firegirl</i>	Tony Abbott	A middle school boy's life is changed when Jessica, a girl disfigured by burns, starts attending his Catholic school while receiving treatment at a local hospital.
	<i>Flipped</i>	Wendelin Van Draanen	Willow Chance is a twelve-year-old genius, obsessed with nature and diagnosing medical conditions, who finds it comforting to count by 7s. It has never been easy for her to connect with anyone other than her adoptive parents, but that hasn't kept her from leading a quietly happy life . . . until now.



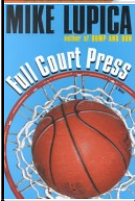
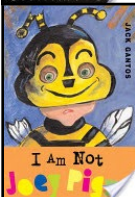
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	Front Desk	Kelly Yang	<i>Front Desk</i> is a middle grade book written by Kelly Yang and published by Scholastic in 2018. Yang's debut book is about ten-year-old Mia Tang and her family who, after a couple years struggling financially, are hired to manage a motel.
	Full Court Press	Mike Lupica	A three-ring circus ensues when a woman plays in the NBA for the first time-and for the worst team in the league.
	Ghost	Jason Reynolds	Aspiring to be the fastest sprinter on his elite middle school's track team, gifted runner Ghost finds his goal challenged by a tragic past with a violent father.
	Ground Zero	Alan Gratz	September 11, 2001, New York City: Brandon is visiting his dad at work, on the 107th floor of the World Trade Center. Out of nowhere, an airplane slams into the tower, creating a fiery nightmare of terror and confusion. And Brandon is in the middle of it all. Can he survive -- and escape?
	Heroes	Alan Gratz	Best friends Frank and Stanley have it good. Their dads—one a Navy pilot, the other a flight crew chief—are stationed at Pearl Harbor in Hawaii, where the air smells like pineapples, the clear blue water sparkles in the sun, and dozens of US battleships, cruisers, and aircraft carriers stand silent sentinel. World War II is raging everywhere else, and it's all anyone can talk about—but so far, the United States has remained neutral.
	Homecoming 	Cynthia Voigt	Abandoned by their mother, four children begin a search for a home and an identity.
	<i>I am not Joey Pigza</i> 	Jack Gantos	Joey's father returns, calling himself Charles Heinz and apologizing for his past bad behavior, and he swears that once Joey and his mother change their names and help him fix up the old diner he has bought, their lives will change for the better.



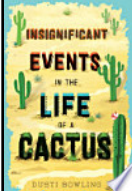
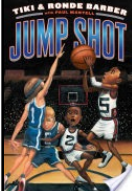
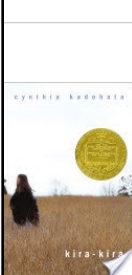
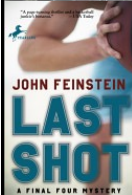
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	<i>Insignificant Events in the Life of a Cactus</i>	Dusti Bowling	Aven Green loves to tell people that she lost her arms in an alligator wrestling match, or a wildfire in Tanzania, but the truth is she was born without them. And when her parents take a job running Stagecoach Pass, a rundown western theme park in Arizona, Aven moves with them across the country knowing that she'll have to answer the question over and over again.
	<i>Jump Shot</i>	Tiki Barber & Ronde Barber	The Barber brothers know their way around a football field—but can they succeed on the basketball court? Find out in this slam dunk with “lively basketball action and life lessons aplenty” (Kirkus Reviews) from NFL superstars and bestselling authors Tiki and Ronde Barber.
	<i>Keep it Together, Keiko Carter</i>	Debbi Michiko Florence	Seventh grade is supposed to be a game changer. And Keiko thinks she's got it covered, especially with Audrey and Jenna by her side to shop for a new look, pick out a prime lunch spot, and even hit up that cute new bubble tea place after school. Her trio is ready to tackle life as they always have... together. But when Audrey decides they need boyfriends before Fall Ball, it looks like things may be changing in all the wrong ways.
	<i>Kira-Kira</i>	Cynthia Kadohata	When Katie and her family move from a Japanese community in Iowa to the Deep South of Georgia, it's Lynn who explains to her why people stop them on the street to stare. And it's Lynn who, with her special way of viewing the world, teaches Katie to look beyond tomorrow. But when Lynn becomes desperately ill, and the whole family begins to fall apart, it is up to Katie to find a way to remind them all that there is always something glittering -- kira-kira -- in the future. Luminous in its persistence of love and hope, Kira-Kira is Cynthia Kadohata's stunning debut in middle-grade fiction.
	<i>The Last Kids on Earth</i>	Max Brallier	<i>The Simpsons</i> meets <i>The Walking Dead</i> in this monstrously funny post-apocalyptic graphic novel for middle-grade readers.
	<i>Last Shot</i>	John Feinstein	As Tiki and Ronde count the days until the start of football season, the basketball coach approaches them looking for new recruits, and Tiki and Ronde sign on.



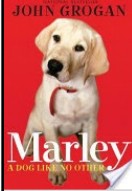
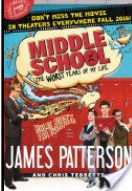
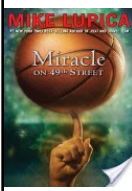
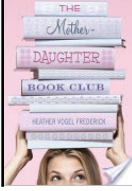
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	<u>Loser</u> 😊	Jerry Spinelli	Even though his classmates from first grade on have considered him strange and a loser, Daniel Zinkoff's optimism and exuberance and the support of his loving family do not allow him to feel that way about himself.	
	<u>Maniac Magee</u>	Jerry Spinelli	While Hidden Valley Junior High has always been a powerhouse in football, the school has never done as well in basketball. Ronde is a good passer, but he needs Tiki to get free to sink his shots. Tiki doesn't feel the inner confidence he felt on the football field: it's one thing to play in the driveway, but it's another to sink one on the court, when so much is on the line. The brothers need a winning attitude—and they need to bring everyone together to win. That is their only way to victory. Can they do it?	
	<u>Marley: A Dog Like No Other</u>	John Grogan	Follows the life story of an exuberant Labrador retriever who gets into perpetual trouble and experiences a range of inspiring adventures. "With unconditional love and loyalty, he brings joy to his family and teaches them what really matters in life."	
	<u>Middle School, The Worst Years of My Life</u>	James Patterson & Chris Tebbetts	Rafe Khatchadorian has enough problems at home without throwing his first year of middle school into the mix. Luckily, he's got an ace plan for the best year ever, if only he can pull it off: With his best friend Leonardo the Silent awarding him points, Rafe tries to break every rule in his school's oppressive Code of Conduct. Chewing gum in class-5,000 points! Running in the hallway-10,000 points! Pulling the fire alarm-50,000 points! But when Rafe's game starts to catch up with him, he'll have to decide if winning is all that matters, or if he's finally ready to face the rules, bullies, and truths he's been avoiding.	
	<u>Miracle on 49th Street</u>	Mike Lupica	After her mother's death, twelve-year-old Molly learns that her father is a basketball star for the Boston Celtics.	
	<u>Mother-Daughter Book Club</u>	Heather Vogel Frederick	When the mothers of four sixth-grade girls with very different personalities pressure them into forming a book club, they find, as they read and discuss "Little Women," that they have much more in common than they could have imagined.	



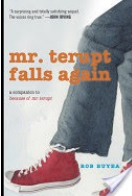
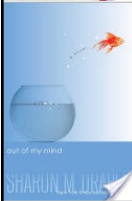
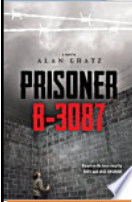
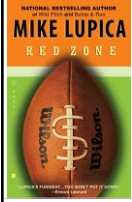
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Realistic Fiction			
	<u>Mr. Terupt Falls Again</u>	Rob Buyea	It's a roller coaster of a year as Mr. Terupt helps his students be the best they can be—and enlists their help to pull off an extra-special project. But will there be a happy ending for all? This title is the second book in a series.
	<u>Out of My Mind</u>	Sharon Draper	Considered by many to be mentally retarded, a brilliant, impatient fifth-grader with cerebral palsy discovers a technological device that will allow her to speak for the first time.
	<u>Prisoner B-3087</u>	Alan Gratz	From Alan Gratz, the #1 New York Times bestselling author of Refugee, comes this wrenching novel about one boy's struggle to survive ten concentration camps during the Holocaust. Based on the inspiring true life story of Jack Gruener.
	<u>Red Zone</u>	Mike Lupica	A sequel to <i>Bump and Run</i> finds New York Hawks co-owner Jack Molloy taking a break abroad after his notorious brothers sell their half of the team to a fractious businessman, who quickly alienates everyone affiliated with the team and causes the departure of the general manager before Molloy enlists outside help.
	<u>Refugee</u>	Alan Gratz	Although separated by continents and decades, Josef, a Jewish boy living in 1930s Nazi Germany; Isabel, a Cuban girl trying to escape the riots and unrest plaguing her country in 1994; and Mahmoud, a Syrian boy in 2015 whose homeland is torn apart by violence and destruction, embark on harrowing journeys in search of refuge, discovering shocking connections that tie their stories together.
	<u>Song for a Whale</u>	Lynne Kelly	Full of heart and poignancy, this affecting story by sign language interpreter Lynne Kelly shows how a little determination can make big waves.



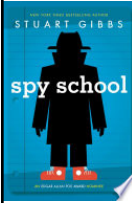
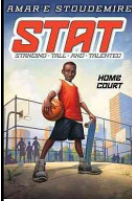
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Realistic Fiction			
	<i>Spy School</i>	Stuart Gibbs	Ben Ripley may only be in middle school, but he's already pegged his dream job: CIA or bust. Unfortunately for him, his personality doesn't exactly scream "secret agent." In fact, Ben is so awkward, he can barely get to school and back without a mishap. Because of his innate nerdiness, Ben is not surprised when he is recruited for a magnet school with a focus on science—but he's entirely shocked to discover that the school is actually a front for a junior CIA academy. Could the CIA really want him? Other books in this series include: <i>Spy Camp</i> <i>Spy Ski School</i>
	<i>STAT series</i>	Amar'e Stoudemire	Eleven-year-old Amar'e Stoudemire has a lot going on. He loves to go skateboarding in the park. He takes his school work very seriously. He helps out with his dad's landscaping company. And he likes to play basketball with his best friends—but just for fun. When a group of older kids start disrespecting his boys on their neighborhood basketball court, there is only one solution. Amar'e must step in and use his athletic ability and intelligence to save the day. Titles in the series include: <i>STAT: Home Court</i> <i>STAT: Double Time</i> <i>STAT: Slam Dunk</i>
	<i>The Season of Styx Malone</i>	Kekla Magoon	Meet Caleb and Bobby Gene, two brothers embarking on a madcap, heartwarming, one-thing-leads-to-another adventure in which friendships are forged, loyalties are tested . . . and miracles just might happen.
	<i>Trapped in Hitler's Web</i>	Marsha Forchuk Skrypuch	In the grip of World War II, Maria has realized that her Nazi-occupied Ukrainian town is no longer safe. Though she and her family might survive, her friend Nathan, who is Jewish, is in grave danger. So Maria and Nathan flee -- into the heart of Hitler's Reich in Austria.
	<i>The Vanderbeekers of 141st Street</i>	Karina Yan Glaser	Told that they will have to move out of their Harlem brownstone just after Christmas, the five Vanderbeeker children, ages four to twelve, decide to change their reclusive landlord's mind.



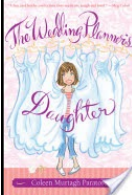
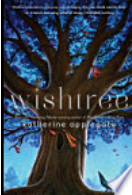
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Realistic Fiction			
	<i>The War that Saved My Life</i>	Kimberly Brubaker Bradley	Ten-year-old Ada has never left her one-room apartment. Her mother is too humiliated by Ada's twisted foot to let her outside. So when her little brother Jamie is shipped out of London to escape the war, Ada doesn't waste a minute—she sneaks out to join him.
	<i>The Wedding Planner's Daughter</i>	Coleen Paratore	Willia, a romantic girl who wants a father, tries to find a husband for her mother, Cape Cod's most popular wedding planner.
	<i>The Wild Robot</i>	Peter Brown	When robot Roz opens her eyes for the first time, she discovers that she is alone on a remote, wild island. Why is she there? Where did she come from? And, most important, how will she survive in her harsh surroundings?
	<i>Wishtree</i>	Katherine Applegate	Red is an oak tree who is many rings old. Red is the neighborhood "wishtree"—people write their wishes on pieces of cloth and tie them to Red's branches. Along with a crow named Bongo and other animals who seek refuge in Red's hollows, this wishtree watches over the neighborhood.
	<i>Wonder</i>	R. J. Palacio	Ten-year-old Auggie Pullman, who was born with extreme facial abnormalities and was not expected to survive, goes from being home-schooled to entering fifth grade at a private middle school in Manhattan, which entails enduring the taunting and fear of his classmates as he struggles to be seen as just another student.

Science Fiction			
	<i>Ender's Game</i> 	Orson Scott Card	Child hero Ender Wiggin must fight a desperate battle against a deadly alien race if mankind is to survive.



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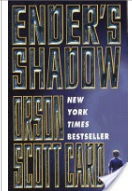
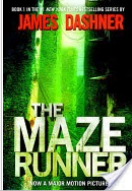
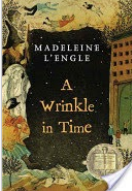


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Science Fiction

	<u>Ender's Shadow</u> 	Orson Scott Card	Follows the life of Ender Wiggin's comrade Bean, from his escape from the mean streets of Rotterdam, to his student days at the Battle School, and to his role as Ender's right hand ally, strategist, and friend in the epic struggle to save Earth from alien invaders.
	<u>The Maze Runner</u>	James Dashner	Sixteen-year-old Thomas wakes up with no memory in the middle of a maze and realizes he must work with the community in which he finds himself if he is to escape.
	Any book in <u>The Mysterious Benedict Society Series</u> 	Trenton Lee Stewart	<i>The Mysterious Benedict Society</i> : After passing a series of mind-bending tests, four children are selected for a secret mission that requires them to go undercover at the Learning Institute for the Very Enlightened, where the only rule is that there are no rules. Other titles in the series include: <u>The Mysterious Benedict Society and the Perilous Journey</u> , <u>The Mysterious Benedict Society and the Prisoner's Dilemma</u> .
	<u>Things Not Seen</u>	Andrew Clements	When fifteen-year-old Bobby wakes up and finds himself invisible, he and his parents and his new blind friend Alicia try to find out what caused his condition and how to reverse it. (<u>Audiobook</u> available)
	<u>A Wrinkle in Time</u> 	Madeleine L'Engle	Meg Murry and her friends become involved with unearthly strangers and a search for Meg's father, who has disappeared while engaged in secret work for the government. (<u>Audiobook</u> available)

Fantasy

	Any book in <u>The Baseball Card Adventure Series</u> 	Dan Gutman	<i>Honus & Me</i> : Joey, who loves baseball but is not very good at it, finds a valuable 1909 Honus Wagner card and travels back in time to meet Honus. Other titles in the series include: <i>Jackie & Me</i> , <i>Babe & Me</i> , <i>Shoeless Joe & Me</i> , <i>Mickey & Me</i> , <i>Abner & Me</i> , <i>Satch & Me</i> , <i>Jim & Me</i> , <i>Roberto & Me</i> , <i>Ray & Me</i> , <i>Ted & Me</i> .
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Challenging Read

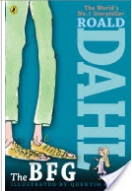
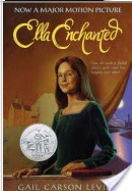
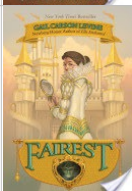
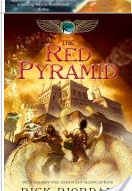


Recommended for the Reluctant Reader

Independent Reading

Grade 6

Fantasy

	<u>The BFG</u> 😊	Roald Dahl	Snatched from her orphanage by a BFG (Big Friendly Giant), who spends his life blowing happy dreams to children, Sophie concocts with him a plan to save the world from nine other man-gobbling cannybull giants.
	<u>Ella Enchanted</u>	Gail Carson Levine	In this novel based on the story of Cinderella, Ella struggles against the childhood curse that forces her to obey any order given to her.
	<u>Fairest</u>	Gail Carson Levine	In a land where beauty and singing are valued above all else, Aza eventually comes to reconcile her unconventional appearance and her magical voice, and learns to accept herself for who she truly is.
	<u>Nevermoor</u>	Jessica Townsend	Morrigan Crow is cursed. Born on an unlucky day, she is blamed for all local misfortunes, from hailstorms to heart attacks - and, worst of all, the curse means that Morrigan is doomed to die at midnight on Eventide.
	<u>Red Pyramid</u>	Rick Riordan	After their father's research experiment unleashes the Egyptian god Set, Carter and Sadie Kane embark on a dangerous journey across the globe--a quest which brings them ever closer to the truth about their family, and their links to a secret order that has existed since the time of the pharaohs.
	<u>Any book in The Series of Unfortunate Events series</u>	Lemony Snicket	<i>The Bad Beginning</i> : The Baudelaire children, Violet, Klaus and baby Sunny, are exceedingly unlucky. Their parents have been killed, and they are forced to go and stay with their Uncle Olaf. It soon turns out that Olaf has evil plans for the children. Other titles in the series include: <i>The Reptile Room</i> , <i>The Wide Window</i> , <i>The Miserable Mill</i> , <i>The Austere Academy</i> ,
	<u>Any book in The Spiderwick Chronicles</u>	Tony DiTerlizzi and Holly Black	<i>The Field Guide</i> : When the Grace children go to stay at their Great Aunt Lucinda's worn Victorian house, they discover a field guide to fairies and other creatures and begin to have some unusual experiences. Other titles in the series include: <i>The Seeing Stone</i> , <i>Lucinda's Secret</i> , <i>The Ironwood Tree</i> .



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